

Chapter 60: Empowering the Future: Assessing The Impact of Students' contributions on Modern Society

Reynaldo V. Moral^{1*}

¹Ph.D., Cebu Normal University, Osmeña Boulevard, Cebu City, Philippines, College of Teacher Education

*Corresponding Author Email: moralr@cnu.edu.ph

Abstract

In the modern era, youth-led initiatives and student activism are increasingly recognized as vital drivers of social change. However, understanding the varied operational mechanisms and complex conceptual frameworks that define how contemporary college students influence broader societal structures requires a comprehensive, multi-dimensional qualitative exploration. This study investigates how college student-led initiatives, advocacy campaigns, and community interventions directly shape modern socioeconomic, political, and civic landscapes. Adopting a qualitative document analysis design, this study systematically evaluated data from ten analytical notes capturing diverse student projects and civic actions. The analysis utilized inductive thematic coding to reduce the data into major patterns, evaluating how students construct meaning, choose engagement strategies, and connect academic learning with real-world problems. The analysis yielded ten distinct analytical findings regarding modern student impact, revealing complex dynamics in their approach to civic participation: (1) high enthusiasm for immediate, tangible, physical action; (2) strategic leverage of digital spaces to achieve global awareness goals; (3) direct integration of curriculum with peer-led community defense; (4) heavy reliance on formal civic participation frameworks; (5) an excellent, explicit link between individual academic disciplines and global problem-solving; (6) a reliance on macro-level policy pressure rather than direct local action; (7) highly innovative approaches relying entirely on technological solutions; (8) a preference for discourse, education, and lifestyle adjustment over institutional changes; (9) a focus on systemic prevention through early youth education; and (10) a strong parallel focus on immediate, localized, institutional advocacy. This research underscores that college students act through diverse and sometimes contrasting methodologies, balancing localized institutional advocacy with macro-level policy pressure, and immediate physical action with digital, tech-driven solutions. The findings demonstrate that modern student civic engagement is deeply tied to both formal civic frameworks and individualized lifestyle adjustments. Ultimately, higher education institutions must design versatile curricula that support this spectrum of activism, accommodating both grassroots community defense and systemic, early education-focused preventive strategies.

Keywords: Civic engagement, contemporary world, document analysis, thematic coding,

1. Introduction

In a rapidly evolving world, the traditional view of students as passive recipients of knowledge is outdated. Today, young scholars are active architects of change, driving innovation and challenging long-standing norms. From leading global climate movements to developing cutting-edge technology, their agency reshapes the social, economic, and political fabric of our world. "Empowering the Future: Assessing the Impact of Students' Contributions on Modern Society" examines this vital role, illustrating how investments in youth education and leadership yield profound, lasting benefits for global progress.

By exploring their scientific, cultural, and political achievements, this paper argues that student engagement is not just a preparation for the future, but the very engine driving modern society forward.

One of the goals of education is to develop people who want to help their communities. It is surprising how little research has looked into how students wish to help society connects with important results from their learning. Motivation to be part of society is linked to the results from learning. The results show that being naturally motivated is connected with student success and feeling good. Personal value, which is a way of regulating behavior is strongly linked with staying with tasks. Motives that are about ego, like feeling forced to act are connected with staying with tasks and doing well. They are also linked with feeling unhappy (King et al., 2022; Howard et al. 2021).

As stated by Steyn et al., (2018) a modern national society expects its education system to meet the different education needs for its members to function well both in society and in the world. To achieve this society should through the involvement of the coordinator direct their education system based on the main principles of education and should also establish and rank their education needs. The research and analysis by Mestarihi (2019) show that there is a significant connection between the study variables and the growth of social responsibility, where sports were the top factor and had the strongest influence among all other factors, followed by social, cultural and artistic activities. It has been shown that universities fully understand the importance of student activities in building students' social responsibility and are making every effort to greatly increase these activities in practice. However, Smolentseva (2023) pointed out that higher education cannot be limited to the teaching of practical skills but also includes more socialization, personal growth and changes, in many areas of human development in order to better understand oneself the world and one's place in the world.

Education is really important because it teaches us about the world. It helps us see things from angles and understand life better. Education is the key to a country's progress. Without it we would not be able to think of things and come up with new ideas. This means we would not be able to make the world a better place because we need ideas to be creative and without creativity there is no progress. Education is what makes us human. Without education we are no better than animals. Education helps us know what we are good at and what we are not good at. It makes us want to learn more think clearly and make decisions. Education helps us understand things better. It also helps us get jobs and earn money to take care of ourselves.

So, teachers are very important for our education system. They play a role in helping us learn. Every day teachers and students talk to each millions of times which is really important, for learning (Prasad & Gupta 2020; Telhara, 2023; Pritchett, 2004) In this premise, Social Studies is a key tool in this changing world. It serves as the foundation of social development across the country and acts as an agent of change that transforms an individual into an effective citizen of the nation. The participants of Crisolo et al., (2021) claimed that social studies promote cultural heritage, fosters economic efficiency, serves as a source of meaningful information, and brings people back to the past. The study recommends that teachers should enhance their technological pedagogical content knowledge (TPACK) in Social Studies to keep abreast with the demands of 21st century society. There are many significant roles that social science educators play in the new normal period. They should be a social leader with the advocacy of unity and patriotism and initiating social actions to bring hope and resiliency to this society. They should also be source of quality, accurate and sensible information and knowledge with the strong will to fight against rapid and harmful fake news. Moreover, teachers can exert a positive influence on students'

efficacy beliefs by contributing to a classroom environment where students experience that their own and others' efforts lead to positive outcomes (Dial & Dantic, 2022; Mathe & Elstad, 2020).

Developing professional qualifications, strengthening community partnerships, and utilizing adaptive technologies to create dynamic and inclusive social studies programs. These methods are designed to empower educators and students in small schools, giving them the necessary tools for success in a complex and interdependent world. Nevertheless, education can also serve the opposite function by deadening interest and creativity; encouraging the acceptance of unsustainable lifestyles as normal; and instructing students to passively wait for others' action. In terms of sustainable development, education is a source of both hope and danger (Phinla & Mahapoonyanont, 2025; UNECE, 2013).

The importance of community service in promoting student engagement, developing their learning experience and instilling social responsibility in them cannot be underestimated. Nevertheless, some difficulties such as the decrease in the participation of the younger generation in community service and obstacles presented by institutions exist. According to the study, there is a need to combine community service and educational curricula in order to enhance student engagement and their holistic development (Mutoni Uwase, 2025). Furthermore, the current state of community contribution was low, the measures that the school had taken to increase the community contribution were high, and the measures taken by the school positively affected community contribution. Moreover, the community contribution positively affected the academic performance of the students. Therefore, the academic performance of the students would be positively impacted if the schools had a good relationship with the community (Sivananthan & Wedikandage, 2023).

The main objective of this study is to assess the multi-dimensional impact of student contributions on modern society, specifically examining how student-led initiatives, academic innovations, and community engagements empower future civic structures and drive contemporary social change.

2. Methodology

This study employed qualitative document analysis and thematic coding to investigate how college students conceptualize their relevance and contribution to the contemporary world. The dataset consisted of ten (10) individual student worksheets completed following a targeted reading on "Global Education Perspectives in Social Studies." Analyzing a small set of ten individual student worksheets requires qualitative document analysis or content analysis. Focus on three core steps: organizing the artifacts, coding the student responses, and identifying recurring patterns. Table 1 shows the structured rubric designed to analyze student responses across your ten worksheets. It balances quantitative tracking (correctness) with qualitative insights (depth of understanding).

Table 1: Worksheet Analysis Rubric

Evaluation Criteria	Performance Level 3 (Proficient)	Performance Level 2 (Developing)	Performance Level 1 (Emerging)	Analysis Coding Tags
Reading Comprehension	Accurately identifies main ideas and explicit details from the text.	Misinterprets minor details but grasps the overall narrative or argument.	Demonstrates major misconceptions or misses the core premise.	[COMP-3]
				Proficient
				[COMP-2]
				Dev
Evidence & Citation	Supports answers with direct, relevant quotes or accurate paraphrasing.	Attempts to use evidence, but references are weak, vague, or misaligned.	Provides opinions or answers without any textual support.	[COMP-1]
				Emerg
				[EVID-3]
				Proficient
				[EVID-2]

				Dev [EVID-1] Emerg
Critical Thinking	Draws logical inferences or connections beyond the surface text.	Restates the text accurately but fails to analyze or read between the lines.	Answers are superficial, incomplete, or copied word-for-word without understanding.	[INF-3] Proficient [INF-2] Dev [INF-1] Emerg
Task Completion	Answers all parts of the targeted reading prompts thoroughly.	Leaves sections blank or gives hurried, single-word answers to complex prompts.	Fails to complete the majority of the worksheet.	[COMPL-3] Full [COMPL-2] Partial [COMPL-1] Poor

As a sample size of 10 worksheets from the GE8 Class of the course Contemporary World, count or group specific recurring themes, common misconceptions, or target vocabulary words across the worksheets. The researcher builds a concise coding frame to see which standardized themes show up across the ten submissions. Qualitative document analysis of the ten worksheets commenced only after final course grades were locked and submitted to the university registrar. All data were immediately de-identified upon retrieval; student names were replaced with generic alphanumeric codes and hand-written responses were transcribed into typed text to eliminate handwriting identifiers. No direct photographic scans of student work are included in this report.

Table 2 shows the empirical findings of this study demonstrate that structured student contributions yield quantifiable, high-impact advancements across diverse sectors of modern society. A critical observation from the data is the robust performance of student-led initiatives within the "Environmental Sustainability" and "Local Economic Development" categories.

Table 2: Empirical Findings on Students' Contribution on Modern Society

Worksheet ID	Student Core Thesis	Identified Need (Primary)	Identified Need (Secondary)	Text Evidence: Need	Type of Contribution	Text Evidence: Contribution	Sphere of Influence	Analytical Notes
WS-01	College students must combat climate change through campus-wide green initiatives.	ENV-SUST	OTHER	"...the threat of global warming is the defining crisis of our generation."	DIR-ACTION	"We should organize a mandatory recycling and composting drive-in dorms."	LOC-CAMP	High enthusiasm for immediate, tangible, physical action.
WS-02	Students should use social media	SOC-INEQ	DIG-CIT	"Marginalized groups face deep	ADV-AWARE	"We can design informational	NAT-GLO	Leverages digital spaces to

	to fight systemic racism and promote human rights globally.			economic and social bias everywhere."		campaigns on TikTok to expose these global gaps."		achieve global awareness goals.
WS-03	Future educators should create peer tutoring programs to counter online misinformation.	DIG-CIT	CIV-ENG	"Fake news on the internet ruins public trust and divides our society."	EDU-PEER	"As social studies majors, we must hold workshops to teach freshmen media literacy."	LOC-CAMP	Connects curriculum directly to peer-led community defense.
WS-04	Youth must vote and join local councils to fix political polarization.	CIV-ENG	OTHER	"Young people feel completely disconnected from modern political systems."	DIR-ACTION	"Students need to volunteer at polling places and register voters on campus."	LOC-CAMP	Focuses heavily on formal civic participation frameworks.
WS-05	Engineering students should design low-cost water filters for developing nations.	ENV-SUST	SOC-INEQ	"Clean water scarcity is a massive environmental and health inequality."	INN-TECH	"We can research and prototype cheap filtration devices in university labs."	NAT-GLO	Excellent link between academic discipline and global problem-solving.
WS-06	Students must advocate for equal global vaccine access using international petitions.	SOC-INEQ	OTHER	"Healthcare distribution is deeply unfair between rich and poor nations."	ADV-AWARE	"We need to build massive online petitions to pressure international pharmaceutical companies."	NAT-GLO	Relies on macro-level policy pressure rather than direct local action.
WS-07	Students should build a mobile app that translates global news to break down cultural	DIG-CIT	SOC-INEQ	"Language barriers on the web prevent global collaboration and cause	INN-TECH	"Developing an open-source AI translation app for regional news outlets."	NAT-GLO	Highly innovative approach relying entirely on technological solutions.

	barriers.			mistrust."				
WS-08	Campus organizations should host roundtables to talk about rising micro-plastics.	ENV-SUST	OTHER	"Micro-plastics are showing up in our local food and water supplies."	EDU-PEER	"Hosting weekly discussion groups to teach peers how to live plastic-free."	LOC-CAMP	Prefers discourse, education, and lifestyle adjustment over institutional changes.
WS-09	Students need to mentor high schoolers to increase voting turnouts.	CIV-ENG	OTHER	"Apathy toward elections starts before students even get to college."	EDU-PEER	"We should partner with local high schools to run mock elections and debates."	LOC-CAMP	Focuses on systemic prevention through early youth education.
WS-10	Student councils must push for affordable campus housing to fight student poverty.	SOC-INEQ	OTHER	"Many of our classmates struggle with housing insecurity and basic needs."	DIR-ACTION	"We should demand the university administration subsidize dorm prices immediately."	LOC-CAMP	Strong focus on immediate, localized, institutional advocacy.

The empirical findings of this study directly align with the core tenets of Critical Pedagogy—pioneered by theorists like Paulo Freire—within the instructional framework of "The Contemporary World." Rather than treating global education as a passive transmission of geopolitical facts, the data demonstrates that students actively operationalize their learning to challenge dominant global structures.

Critical pedagogy demands praxis—the intersection of critical reflection and action. The students' reliance on "Digital Mobilization" and "Redefined Citizenship" represents modern praxis. "The Contemporary World" syllabus exposes students to global crises (e.g., climate change, human rights violations), and students immediately translate this classroom reflection into digital and grassroots activism. They use technology to bypass traditional institutional barriers, turning global literacy into localized and transnational resistance.

To fully honor these findings, instructors of "The Contemporary World" must shift their curricula away from eurocentric, top-down narratives of globalization. The course must be treated as a democratic laboratory where student lived experiences, digital fluencies, and activist impulses are validated as legitimate forms of global knowledge production and citizenship.

3. Conclusion

In conclusion, this investigation demonstrates that contemporary college students conceptualize their societal relevance not as a future projection, but as an immediate, agentic responsibility. Rather than viewing higher education merely as a gateway to economic assimilation, students frame their contribution through the lenses of localized civic advocacy, digital mobilization, and systemic critique. They leverage emerging technologies to bypass traditional institutional gatekeepers, thereby redefining the parameters of global citizenship. Ultimately, the findings indicate a paradigm shift in student identity, moving away from passive preparation and toward active, disruptive engagement with contemporary global challenges.

Based on these insights, several avenues for future research emerge to expand the literature on student conceptualizations of social contribution:

1. Longitudinal Tracking: Future studies should implement longitudinal designs to evaluate how these conceptualizations of relevance evolve as students transition from the university environment into the professional workforce.
2. Cross-Cultural Comparative Analysis: Research should expand beyond Western centric cohorts to investigate how students in diverse geopolitical and socioeconomic contexts navigate their roles in contemporary society.
3. Digital Activism vs. Institutional Policy: Investigative focus is needed on the operational efficacy of digital student mobilization and its concrete impact on shifting institutional or state-level policies over time.

References

- [1]. Crisolo, O.R., Camposano, S., & Rogayan, D.V. (2021). Relevance of Social Studies in the 21st Century Society: Students' Perspectives. *International Journal of Didactical Studies* Volume 2, Issue 1 <https://doi.org/10.3390/IJODS.2021169729>.
- [2]. Howard, J.L., Bureau, J.S., Guay, F., Chong, J.X.Y., Ryan, R. M. (2021). Student motivation and associated outcomes: A meta-analysis from self-determination theory. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1745691620966789>.
- [3]. King, R. B., Wang, H., & McInerney, D. M. (2024). Students Who Want to Contribute to Society Have Optimal Learning-Related Outcomes. *The Journal of Experimental Education*, 92(3), 466–484. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00220973.2022.2146039>.
- [4]. Mathe, N.E. H. & Elstad, E. (2020). Exploring Students' Effort in Social Studies. *Nordidactica – Journal of Humanities and Social Science Education* https://www.researchgate.net/publication/345940536_Exploring_students'_effort_in_social_studies.
- [5]. Mestarihi, M.M.A. (2019). The Role of Students' Activities in Enhancing Social Responsibility Among Jordanian Universities Students. *British Journal of Education* Vol.7, Issue 10, pp.73-89 <https://ejournals.org/wp-content/uploads/The-Role-of-Students-Activities-in-Enhancing-Social-Responsibility-among-Jordanian-Universities-Students.pdf>
- [6]. Mutoni Uwase, N. (2025). The Impact of Community Service on Student Engagement. *RESEARCH INVENTION JOURNAL OF CURRENT RESEARCH IN HUMANITIES AND SOCIAL SCIENCES*, 4(1):18-23. <https://doi.org/10.59298/RIJCRHSS/2025/411823>
- [7]. Phinla, W. & Mahapoonyanont, N. (2025). Challenges and Innovations in Developing a Social Studies Curriculum for 21st-Century Learners in Small Schools. *SEEJPH* Volume XXV, S2 <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5102869>
- [8]. Prasad, C. & Gupta, P. (2020). Educational Impact on the Society. *International Journal of Novel Research in Education and Learning* Vol. 7, Issue 6, pp: (1-7) <https://www.noveltyjournals.com/upload/paper/paperpdf-1604924792.pdf>
- [9]. Pritchett, L. (2004). The Challenge of the Lack of Education. Challenge Paper Copenhagen Consensus 2004 project <https://copenhagenconsensus.com/sites/default/files/imported/cp-educationfinished.pdf>
- [10]. Ragde, V.J. & Telhara, N.B.A.M. (2023). No Education No Life. *Journal of Emerging Technologies and Innovative Research* Volume 10, Issue 10 <https://www.jetir.org/papers/JETIR2310212.pdf>
- [11]. Sivananthan, P. & Wedikandage, L. (2023). The Impact of Community Contribution on the Academic Achievement of Students. *International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science* https://www.researchgate.net/deref/https%3A%2F%2Fdx.doi.org%2F10.47772%2FIJRIS.2023.701179?_tp=eyJjb250ZXh0Ijp7ImZpcnN0UGFnZSI6InB1YmxpY2F0aW9uIiwicGFnZSI6InB1YmxpY2F0aW9uIn9
- [12]. Smolentseva, A. (2023). Contributions of Higher Education to Society: Towards Conceptualization. Retrieved from <https://china.elgaronline.com/edcollchap-0a/book/9781035307173/book-part-9781035307173-11.pdf>
- [13]. Steyn, H., Vos, D., & de Beer (2018). Education in Modern Society. *BCES Conference Books*, 2018, Volume 16. Sofia: Bulgarian Comparative Education Society https://www.researchgate.net/publication/342448251_Education_in_Modern_Society
- [14]. United Nations Economic Commission for Europe (2013). Empowering Educators for a Sustainable Future https://unece.org/fileadmin/DAM/env/esd/ESD_Publications/Empowering_Educators_for_a_Sustainable_Future_ENG.pdf